career, and then, all of a sudden, she had to stop and focus all her energy and attention instead on this tiny new baby who was completely dependent on her. I'm sure any mum must recognize those feelings. It's not like it wasn't what Victoria wanted to be doing but it was a giant shock to the system. Her life, and everything about it, changed almost overnight and in ways that nothing could ever have prepared her for. If anything, it was even worse when she moved up to Manchester, away from her family and friends.

We hardly went out anywhere; hardly ever had people round unless it had been arranged in advance. I'd go off to training and Victoria would be left on her own, feeling trapped in the apartment. Even the gardens weren't private. Photographers would suddenly turn up with their lenses pointed in over the back gate. I think Victoria got pretty down. She stuck it out, though, and I'm grateful and proud of her that she did: we'd both decided that what was best for Brooklyn would be for the three of us—our little family—to be together as much as we could.

From April 1999 onwards, I was playing two games a week, which made trips to London pretty difficult to squeeze in. That was part of the reason Victoria decided to bring Brooklyn north when she did. It meant so much to me, having them there while the season flew by, getting more and more intense as each match came and went. I'd rush home afterwards and there would be my boy and his mum, waiting for me.

There were so many big games that spring but one stands out above the rest: the one that made everything else possible. Ask any United player, any United fan, and they'll tell you which one I mean: the Wednesday night, April 14 1999, at Villa Park. The FA Cup semi-final replay against Arsenal. We'd been disappointed not to win the first time, on the Sunday afternoon, when it finished 0–0, but as soon as we got to the ground on the evening of the replay, you could tell it was going to turn out to be something special.

Semi-finals are always exciting to play in; an evening kick-off, under floodlights, just made it seem even more dramatic. Arsenal were the closest team to United in the Premiership and here we were, extra-time and penalties if necessary, to decide who'd be going to Wembley for the Cup Final. I remember sitting in the dressing room forty minutes ahead of kick-off. *I've never scored against them. What would it feel like to get a goal against Arsenal tonight?*

Villa Park has always been a lucky ground for me: I'd scored the winner in our last semi-final there against Chelsea. And now, against Arsenal, I only